CONCEPT PAPER

Land + Launch NWA

A Regional Innovation Initiative

A regional innovation initiative connecting global founders to the industries that anchor Northwest Arkansas — consumer commerce, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation. Led by the Greater Bentonville Area Chamber of Commerce. Delivered by Arkade.

DOCUMENT TYPE	UPDATED	GRANT REQUEST
DRAFT CONCEPT PAPER	APRIL 2026	~$1.5M (3 YEARS)

Executive Summary

Northwest Arkansas is home to one of the most concentrated industry ecosystems in the world.

Five global headquarters anchor the region's core industries — consumer commerce (Walmart, Sam's Club), food and agriculture (Tyson Foods, Simmons Foods), and logistics and transportation (J.B. Hunt) — alongside more than 1,100 CPG brand offices. Three of those companies — Walmart, Tyson Foods, and J.B. Hunt — rank in the Fortune 500. Combined annual revenue from NWA-headquartered companies exceeds **$750 billion**, more than the GDP of metropolitan Boston.

$750B+	**5**	**1,100+**
annual revenue from NWA-HQ companies	global headquarters across anchor industries	CPG brand offices in the region

While the region continues to grow in economic strength and national visibility, it lacks the structured infrastructure to intentionally convert global founder interest into measurable regional economic impact. Out-of-market growth-stage B2B technology companies want access to Bentonville's industry leaders and ecosystem. However, without a formalized landing pathway, curated programming, and coordinated regional infrastructure, interest does not consistently translate into sustained presence, ecosystem participation, or long-term contribution to the region.

The Greater Bentonville Area Chamber of Commerce, in partnership with Arkade, proposes a three-year initiative to build the structured ecosystem infrastructure NWA needs — supporting growth-stage B2B technology companies serving the region's anchor industries through cohort-based programming, ecosystem integration, and community-anchored support. Land + Launch NWA will be administered by the Chamber as fiduciary partner and delivered by Arkade's commercial growth platform.

> **Land + Launch NWA is built around the founders themselves** — providing the workspace, programming, mentorship, and ecosystem access growth-stage companies need to commit to Northwest Arkansas long-term.

This effort will:

- Engage growth-stage B2B technology companies serving consumer commerce, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation
- Connect global founders to NWA's ecosystem — mentors, advisors, talent, and industry leaders
- Strengthen regional innovation programming open to cohort participants and the broader community
- Elevate Bentonville's national and global profile as a hub for applied innovation
- Build structured pathways between local talent and the next generation of high-growth companies

We are seeking **$1.5 million** in catalytic grant funding, matched by approximately **$822,000** in private and in-kind contributions from Arkade and the Chamber over three years. Grant funding will support five key components:

Ecosystem Intelligence and Strategic Positioning; Program Recruitment and Founder Curation; Innovation Programming and Industry Convenings; Embedding and Expansion Support; and Talent and Ecosystem Integration.

The Challenge: Opportunity without Infrastructure

Northwest Arkansas offers a rare concentration of global industry leadership across consumer commerce, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation, alongside major CPG presence, a sophisticated talent pool, rapid population growth, and supportive economic development leadership. However, the region competes globally for innovation companies that often default to coastal U.S. cities or other international hubs. The region currently lacks structured ecosystem infrastructure to intentionally connect global founders, talent, and industry.

At the same time, international and out-of-market growth-stage B2B technology companies face significant barriers when entering U.S. enterprise markets, including limited access to decision-makers, regulatory and operational complexity, lack of trusted local networks, high cost of entry, and cultural and commercial differences.

Today, without Land + Launch NWA:

- Companies from outside the region conduct cold outreach or visit Bentonville for 1–2 days of meetings
- Introductions are made informally, without structure or sustained follow-through
- Most companies leave without establishing a sustained presence
- There is no formalized pathway connecting founders to workspace, programming, mentorship, regulatory navigation, workforce, and ecosystem support

Without intentional ecosystem infrastructure connecting founders to industry leaders, programming, workspace, regulatory navigation, workforce pipelines, and economic development support, Northwest Arkansas risks losing high-growth companies to more coordinated ecosystems such as Austin, Atlanta, New York, and Toronto.

> The intent is to bridge those barriers with structured programming, ecosystem integration, and community-anchored support — positioning Northwest Arkansas as a leading U.S. hub for applied innovation in consumer commerce, food, and logistics.

The Solution: Land + Launch NWA

Program Overview

The partnership will launch **Land + Launch NWA** — a structured, cohort-based, and community-integrated initiative supporting growth-stage B2B technology companies serving Northwest Arkansas' anchor industries: consumer commerce, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation.

This initiative establishes a clear and supported pathway for international and out-of-market founders to engage with the region, build relationships across industry, talent, and capital, and integrate into the broader NWA innovation ecosystem.

Land + Launch NWA will operate as an annual cohort-based initiative supporting **6–12 growth-stage technology companies** through a structured six-month engagement. Participating companies will receive dedicated guidance, curated introductions to enterprise partners, investors, and ecosystem leaders, access to physical workspace at Arkade, and business establishment support through Chamber resources.

The program provides structured market immersion, regulatory and relocation navigation, industry and cultural education, ongoing matchmaking, and full integration into the broader regional innovation ecosystem, ensuring companies are positioned to build partnerships, hire locally, and establish long-term presence in Northwest Arkansas.

> **Land + Launch NWA is built around the founders themselves** — providing the workspace, programming, mentorship, and ecosystem access that growth-stage companies need to commit to Northwest Arkansas long-term.

Target Company Profile

- Native to an international (primary) or a non-local U.S. (secondary) market
- B2B technology serving NWA's anchor industries — including consumer commerce (in-store, ecommerce, omnichannel), food and agriculture, logistics and transportation, AI and data analytics, automation and robotics, and sustainability and packaging
- Series A+ growth-stage startups
- Demonstrated product-market fit, revenue generating or late-stage pilot phase
- Companies actively seeking U.S. market entrance or expansion
- Firms capable of hiring locally within 12 months

Five Pillars of Programming

01 Ecosystem Intelligence and Strategic Positioning

THE FOUNDATION LAYER

Strengthen understanding of the regional innovation landscape and identify opportunities to connect entrepreneurs and talent to industry.

Grant-supported Activities

- Research tools (Harmonic, CRM, data subscriptions)
- Sector mapping across consumer commerce, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation
- Global company identification
- Investor mapping
- Competitive landscape analysis
- Impact dashboarding

02 Program Recruitment and Founder Curation

THE ACQUISITION LAYER

Source and curate high-potential founders from around the world to participate in structured programming.

Grant-supported Activities

- Dedicated recruitment/ecosystem growth lead
- International roadshows and recruitment events
- Embassy/trade partnerships
- Inbound innovation summits
- Targeted outreach campaigns

Pillar 3 — Innovation Programming & Industry Convenings

THE COLLABORATION LAYER

Create consistent opportunities for learning, collaboration, and knowledge exchange — open to cohort participants, local founders, and the broader community.

- Annual cohort of 6–12 growth-stage B2B technology companies serving NWA's anchor industries
- 6-month structured engagement model
- Dedicated programming and ecosystem support
- Curated introductions to enterprise partners, investors, and ecosystem leaders
- Physical workspace access at Arkade
- Business establishment guidance through Chamber resources

Grant-supported Activities

- **Bentonville Market Immersion Week** (1× each company) — A 2–4 day welcome visit itinerary planned with team orientation, minimum of 5 warm intro meetings to local leaders or potential customers, and tours across restaurants, museums, trails, and the Bentonville campus.
- **Visa and relocation navigation** (1× each company)
- **Industry education workshops** (monthly) — Curated 10-person lunches or workshops discussing demand-driven innovation topics across consumer commerce, food, and logistics; with a focus on what works locally and culturally for businesses in Bentonville.
- **BiteSized conference with industry decision makers** (quarterly) — Closed-door, curated discussions between founders, enterprise executives, and industry investors; with a focus on partnership acceleration and ecosystem alignment.
- **Access to all Arkade and Chamber ecosystem events** (networking lunches, forums, and summits) throughout program, including the Bi-Annual NWA Tech Summit: a high-visibility regional convening hosted by the Chamber and produced in partnership with Arkade. Includes global founder showcases, industry innovation panels, strategy sessions, media engagement, and talent recruitment programming.
- Introductions to customers, partners, or potential talent throughout program
- Pilot facilitation or implementation support

Pillars 4 & 5

04 Embedding and Expansion Support

THE RETENTION LAYER

Transform initial visits into sustained presence, helping companies build enduring operations and meaningful local impact.

Grant-supported Activities

- Legal & regulatory navigation
- Entity formation support
- Visa guidance
- Workspace access
- Investor introductions
- Community integration
- Relocation support
- Local media content creation and engagement

05 Talent and Ecosystem Integration

THE COMPOUNDING LAYER

Build structured pathways connecting local talent to innovation-driven opportunities, helping companies build enduring local impact.

Grant-supported Activities

- Innovation Fellows — paid internships within Arkade member companies
- Career pathway development with University of Arkansas and regional institutions
- Embedding in local industry panels, workshops, and meetups with external groups
- Advisor/Mentor Workshop
- Talent Network Outreach and Recommendation

Measurable Outcomes (Over 3 Years)

Clear Key Performance Indicators are aligned with grant activities to ensure measurable outcomes over a three-year period. The initiative tracks outcomes across program engagement and broader economic indicators, with quarterly reporting to the Chamber.

Pillar 1 — Ecosystem Intelligence and Strategic Positioning

- 500+ qualified global B2B technology companies serving NWA's anchor industries identified and segmented
- 150+ high-priority company targets actively tracked and engaged
- 50+ corporate relocation or expansion leads generated
- 10+ sector opportunity or ecosystem intelligence reports produced
- Comprehensive ecosystem impact dashboard developed and maintained

Pillar 2 — Program Recruitment and Founder Curation

- 60+ founders engaged in programming — global and local
- 25+ formal partnership relationships established with international trade organizations, embassies, accelerators, or global innovation networks
- 8–10 global industry events attended annually

Pillar 3 — Innovation Programming and Industry Convenings

- 20–30 growth-stage companies supported through structured programming
- 100+ curated ecosystem introductions facilitated — mentors, advisors, talent, and industry partners
- 10+ innovation convenings and public programming events produced annually, open to cohort participants and the broader community
- 75+ curated enterprise introductions resulting in documented follow-on engagement
- $2M+ in direct regional economic impact from program-related travel, events, and business activity

Pillar 4 — Embedding and Expansion

- 10+ companies establishing a formal operating presence
- 30+ high-skill jobs offered in Northwest Arkansas
- 70%+ retention rate of participating companies maintaining active regional engagement 24 months post-program
- 15+ companies securing permanent office or operational space in the region

Pillar 5 — Talent and Ecosystem Integration

- 15–20 students placed through the Innovation Fellows program (University of Arkansas VIP program partnership)
- 100+ curated mentor, advisor, or executive engagements facilitated
- 10% of event or programming seats allocated to University of Arkansas undergraduate or graduate students
- Sustained ecosystem growth measured through participation, programming, and regional vitality indicators

Governance & Budget

Governance & Structure

To ensure compliance, transparency, and alignment with philanthropic best practices:

- The Greater Bentonville Chamber of Commerce will serve as fiduciary
- All grant funds will be administered through the Chamber
- Funds will be allocated strictly toward approved programmatic activities
- Arkade will serve as commercialization delivery partner under a formal agreement
- Clear KPIs and quarterly reporting will be established
- Annual public economic impact reporting will be produced

Chamber leads on:

- Grant applications and compliance
- Regional economic development alignment
- Civic and corporate introductions
- Marketing and visibility
- Relocation assistance
- Economic impact metrics

Arkade leads on:

- Recruitment strategy execution
- Programming and support delivery
- Company relationship management
- Commercialization outcomes tracking
- Ecosystem engagement coordination

Budget Overview (3-Year Total: ~$2.3M)

$1.5M	$822K	$2.3M
Grant Request	Arkade + Chamber Match	Total Program Budget

Major Budget Categories

Personnel: Head of Global Innovation Growth · Member Education & Programming Manager · Partial allocation: Director of Portfolio Operations · Contracted event coordination

Program Infrastructure: Workspace allocation · Software tools (Harmonic AI, CRM systems) · Marketing support

Events & Convening: Quarterly mini-conference · Monthly ecosystem programming · Bi-annual Tech Summit production

Travel & Recruitment: International recruitment travel · Key domestic industry events · Inbound summit travel

Administration: 10–15% program administration allocation · Fiscal oversight through Chamber

Cost Share & Why This Matters Now

Cost Share & Sustainability Model

This initiative is designed as catalytic funding, not permanent subsidy.

YEAR 1	YEAR 2	YEAR 3
100%	**65 / 35**	**30 / 70**
Grant — infrastructure build & first cohort	Grant / Match	Grant / Earned Revenue + Sponsorship + Match

Long-term sustainability mechanisms

- Company participation fees
- Corporate sponsorship
- Event ticket revenue
- Increased Arkade membership beyond cohort
- Regional economic development support

Why This Matters Now

Northwest Arkansas stands at a pivotal moment. The region has:

- **Anchor industry concentration:** five global headquarters across consumer commerce, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation, alongside more than 1,100 CPG brand offices
- **Rapid population growth:** supplying talent and consumer demand, with population projected to exceed one million by 2050
- **Corporate density:** three Fortune 500 headquarters and an unmatched concentration of industry decision-makers and innovation capacity
- **National visibility:** a recognized hub for applied innovation across consumer commerce, food, and logistics

To capitalize on these advantages, the region must intentionally build structured ecosystem infrastructure that connects global founders, talent, and industry. Competing ecosystems across the U.S. are aggressively pursuing the same innovators. This initiative ensures Bentonville becomes not just a destination for meetings, but the place where the next generation of consumer commerce, food, and logistics innovation gets built.

The Proven Model: Regional Comparables

The structured ecosystem infrastructure this initiative proposes is not an untested concept — it is an established and growing category of regional investment that has produced measurable community and economic returns in comparable metros across the U.S. and internationally. NWA is not pioneering a new idea. It is building on a proven one.

Opportunity Austin / Global Launch Pad (Austin, TX)

Backed by the Austin Chamber of Commerce — structurally the most direct analog to what Arkade and the Chamber are proposing — Austin's program has contributed to **400+ international companies** now operating in the region. Austin is the most direct U.S. market competitor to NWA for attracting growth-stage technology companies. The fact that Austin has formalized a Chamber-backed ecosystem program while NWA has not is a competitive risk this initiative directly addresses.

Georgia Tech Enterprise Innovation Institute (Atlanta, GA)

Since launching in 2018, Georgia Tech's cohort-based program has achieved a **68% U.S. expansion rate** — 15 of 22 participating international companies successfully expanded into the U.S. market. This compares to an industry average of approximately 30% for informal market entry, demonstrating that structured programming — not just introductions — is the decisive variable in conversion.

Toronto Global (Toronto, Ontario)

The closest operational model to what Arkade and the Chamber are proposing, at a larger scale. Over its history, Toronto Global has facilitated **260 structured engagements** generating **33,000+ jobs** and **$1.3 billion CAD in cumulative community tax impact**. In 2023/24 alone, 44 structured engagements produced 5,527 jobs and $217.5M CAD in tax impact. These numbers establish that structured ecosystem investment programs are high-return regional infrastructure.

> **The bottom line:** Every comparable metro that has built this infrastructure has seen measurable community and economic returns. NWA has everything those metros have — and in consumer commerce, food, and logistics, considerably more. What it has lacked is the infrastructure to connect that advantage to opportunity. This initiative builds it.

The Partnership Case & Long-Term Vision

The Partnership Case

Northwest Arkansas sits at a rare and time-sensitive inflection point. It has global industry concentration, a growing talent base, civic momentum, and the institutional density that most regions spend decades trying to build. What it lacks — in the Chamber's own words — is *"a more coordinated effort among all entities"* and *"a dedicated facility for innovation startups."* This initiative is the direct answer to that gap.

Two organizations — each essential, neither sufficient alone — are positioned to close it.

FIDUCIARY & CIVIC LEAD

Greater Bentonville Area Chamber of Commerce

Brings the civic mandate and institutional credibility to make this work at a regional scale. Its own Bold Bentonville strategic plan explicitly names this kind of coordinated ecosystem infrastructure as a priority — with a proven 501(c)(3) fiduciary structure for public-private initiatives. The Chamber does not just endorse this initiative. It has been calling for it.

PROGRAM DELIVERY PARTNER

Arkade

Brings the platform and commercial expertise to deliver what the ecosystem has been missing. Designed to help businesses from outside the region gain access to NWA's innovation ecosystem, Arkade connects founders to the mentors, advisors, industry leaders, and partners they need to succeed. Arkade does not replicate what exists — it delivers what no other entity in the region is currently structured to do.

The initiative is supported by a coalition of senior operators, investors, and industry leaders committed to strengthening Northwest Arkansas as a hub for consumer commerce, food, and logistics innovation. Together, this partnership structure delivers the full stack that regional ecosystem development requires — private-sector execution and civic accountability — building something Northwest Arkansas will benefit from for decades.

Long-Term Vision

Over time, the program will evolve into a self-sustaining, self-reinforcing platform supported by corporate sponsorships, membership participation, private investment partnerships, and revenue-generating services. This structure ensures enduring impact while scaling access and opportunities for global founders building across consumer commerce, food, and logistics.

Within five years, Northwest Arkansas will be recognized as a leading U.S. hub for applied innovation in consumer commerce, food, and logistics — the place where global founders, talent, and industry connect at scale. The region will become a magnet for high-growth companies, cultivate a nationally recognized innovation ecosystem, and provide a lasting home for international firms building U.S. operations.

Through strong public-private collaboration, this initiative will catalyze innovation, accelerate job creation, and drive sustained ecosystem growth, solidifying Northwest Arkansas' position as a globally competitive, innovation-driven region.